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ASSESSMENT OF WRITING IN A SECOND LANGUAGE: VARIOUS TOOLS AND STRATEGIES

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10.1 INTRODUCTION

As teachers of pre-primary and primary grades, we have observed that children face a lot of difficulty in writing. They participate in discussions and story sessions enthusiastically, but while doing any task that involves writing, they make excuses, take time, get easily distracted and seem to be disinterested. As teachers, we need to understand what makes writing tasks so difficult and uninteresting for children. There is a dichotomy in the experiences provided to children and the goal. We need to understand that our ultimate goal is to make children write independently and to express themselves through different genres. However, when we start teaching them writing, we do not engage them in such writing activities that are meaningful. Usually they receive instructions about parts of grammar, sounds, spellings and drills of writing practice separately. This method of teaching takes away interest from the task and fails to develop their ability to write effectively for various purposes.

If we analyse this closely, every effective piece of writing is created through a process which involves engaging with content, ideas, organisation of thoughts, and fetching appropriate vocabulary to communicate what one really wants

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through drafting and editing. The process of developing children as writers is the same. This requires focusing on the process of writing, along with developing a grip on the language. The difficulty intensifies when it comes to writing in a second language (English) for young learners. The writing process for early years also goes through developmental shifts from scribbling, drawing, to inventing spelling, etc.

In most of our classrooms, writing is not approached with this view of ‘process writing’. Also, in the case of English as a Second Language (ESL), this poses a dual challenge. This is because children come from diverse linguistic backgrounds, and usually English is not their first language. Their exposure and interaction to the language and text likely begins at school. As a second language teacher, helping children develop writing skills and assessing their writing in the given scenario is indeed a complex and challenging task. Writing independently in the first language is also challenging. However, in a second language, there are further layers that we will examine in this chapter. We will also discuss what we, as teachers of a second of the learners’ journey, can do to support and facilitate the process.

Let us read a classroom scenario given below in one of the classes of grade 2 where teacher is doing a writing activity with children:

Grade II Free-writing in Second Language

Children are scattered around the classroom—some at their desks, some near the book corner, others by the blackboard or the charts displayed on the wall, and a few sitting next to the teacher. Some children are seated in pairs, engaged in quiet discussions.

The teacher is multitasking—moving around the room, pausing occasionally to look into a child’s notebook, then hurrying back to her desk to jot something down on small sticky notes and pins them to the soft board. One of the notes read:

“Nafisa again chose to write about her younger brother who is only a year old.”

Some children reached the teacher and she started helping to resolve their queries.

Child 1: I am not sure what to write.

Teacher: That’s all right. Let’s try to recall all that happened since last



Tuesday. Now think what among those you remember distinctly and would like to write about.

After a pause when the other two children still looked confused, she probed further with more inputs.

Teacher: It does not have to be only a happy event or special one. It can also be something that made you think deeply or touched your heart strongly. It can also be a unique observation you made recently.

Child 1: I saw a small flower always remaining at top of a small transparent bottle. I filled the bottle with water and then put the flower. Even when I moved the water upside down, the flower moved to the top. I found it very interesting. My friends also kept playing with it for hours.

Teacher: That's wonderful! Maybe you can add details—what flower was it? Why do you think it stayed up? What else it you want to share about it with your friends.

Meanwhile, one of the other children approaches the teacher.

Child 2: Ma'am, I can't write the part where she carefully chose equal-sized flowers for the garland and pierced them to show their best side up.

Teacher: Maybe you can break that into 2 or 3 small sentences instead of writing that whole information in one.

The third child still couldn't decide what to write about. The teacher encouraged him to look around the classroom, browse through some books, and see if something inspired him. He went to the book corner and picked up the book the teacher had read to them the previous day. Observing him, the teacher noted in her register: 'Rahul has difficulty in thinking about the topic to write but he is beginning to make connections with what is being read to him in class and showing interest in story sessions now. Soon he will develop vocabulary to start formulating text in the new language too.'

During another round of observation, the teacher noticed that the child who had spoken about the floating flower had not started writing yet. The teacher stopped to ask why.

Child 1: I am unable to think what do I write first, how I got the idea to put the flower in the bottle or straight from when I saw the flower coming up after flipping the bottle?

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Teacher: Both are fine. but first you must think of what all you want to share with your friends here, that will help you in deciding where to begin with.

As soon as she finished speaking a boy at the corner of the room asked her loudly, “ma’am I forgot how to write yesterday.” She went on board and wrote ‘Yester’ and stopped, then read aloud yester and asked him look in the calendar and tell her what is the spelling of day, then with his help completed writing the word ‘yesterday’ on board. When she went near him after some time she noted he had written only one sentence till then ‘Yesterday I went to a park’, while others had written 3-4 lines about the topic they had chosen. She went to him and whispered that he may want to also draw that park he visited. This idea illuminated his face, and in no time, he created a beautiful scene of the park with himself in it along with other children around with utmost details one can ask for to prompt a fine piece of writing using that. The teacher decided to discuss his drawings the next day and use it to help him structure his writing. She also planned to pair him with Rahul when they worked on it further. She made a note in her plan that she needs to focus on four children specifically the next day. Just then the bell rang and she asked all the children to put their work in their respective working-folders to be worked upon and reviewed again next day.

In the example given above, we can see children composing something on a topic of their own choice, and you would have noticed that it was not an easy task for all of them. Some were struggling with ideas, some with how to express something they value in appropriate language and words, some even struggled with spellings, and there were a few who could not even choose a topic to write on. Hence, the support that the teacher was providing to them was at the level of their need; a standard instruction common for all was not given. This also inherently involves assessing them through observing closely where each child is and what their individual struggle points are, and even their strengths to leverage them further. Knowing their context, knowing them as individuals, helps to further decide how to support them to become independent and efficient in the writing process.

The key point is to create meaningful experiences around a writing task that is engaging. It also means moving away from rote learning or traditional grammar-focused instruction. Some of the ways to make a writing task interesting for the learners are by using literature, creative materials, interactive activities and

allowing personal narratives to take place in class. Focusing on the process of writing is as crucial as the end product of writing, along with giving space to the learner's individual and developmental needs. Hence, assessment of writing needs to be integrated with classroom processes, and it can also be used for enhancing learning. This calls for day-to-day assessment of children during the teaching-learning process.



10.2 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After completion of this chapter, the learner:

- Explains with examples that assessing second language writing is a continuous process, not a one-time task;
- Understands the challenges of L2 writing and values diverse assessment methods and constructive feedback;
- Illustrates various tools and rubrics to assess writing for different purposes and supports learners through portfolios;
- Designs learning experiences that guide children in organising ideas, using grammar in context, and writing across genres through appropriate assessment techniques.

10.3 WRITING WITH MEANING

10.3.1 Understanding the Writing Process

Let us relook at the above example where, we read of a grade 2 English writing classroom. In that, children were grappling with a free-writing task. It was part of a routine activity in the class, yet every child's struggle points were different pertaining to the same task of 'free-writing' expression. We can also tell that children were at different levels of language learning. Some children struggle with words and spellings. Some have difficulty with speed and putting their ideas into text. Others find it hard to organise their thoughts clearly. Nafisa, for example, prefers to write only on familiar topics, while Rahul finds it difficult to even decide what to write about.

The trouble does not finish when the topic is chosen or ideas are gathered around it; composing and sequencing thoughts and events is yet another challenge built into the task of writing. Hence, the process of writing involves going through



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these stages, such as gathering ideas about the topic to write on, preparing a draft, taking feedback, peer review, editing and proofreading it, self-evaluation of one's piece, and then final composition for publishing. The repeated emphasis on various techniques, a developmental perspective, and the acceptance of errors implies that writing is seen as a process, not just a final product. Thus, an assessment that aims to support the process of writing must reflect things like valuing drafts, revisions, and the growth of each writer over time.

10.3.2 Challenges of Writing in a Second Language

We have seen through the above examples that the challenges faced by the children while doing a free writing task differ from one child to another. There are struggle points like content and ideas, as well as grammatical or mechanical parts of writing, such as spellings, structure of sentences, vocabulary, etc. Let us look at each of these issues separately.

- It is also observed in children writing in a second language that they become so caught up in the mechanical forms of the language, like syntax, vocabulary, and spelling, that they have trouble sustaining thought on the topic they are composing, and hence they become conscious of expressing themselves freely in that language.
- For students learning a second language, dealing with errors may be done cautiously so that they do not get discouraged by pointing out too many errors. Yet we may find that sometimes students of ESL (English as a Second Language) want accurate feedback on errors more directly than native speakers because the teacher may be the sole or only source through which they receive feedback or input into the new language (Carroll et al., 1996).
- Since the exposure to English as a second language, both in written and oral form, may be limited, students may not have the appropriate vocabulary or language to express the flow of thoughts in a composition.
- The second language in our country is introduced at the same time as the development of writing skills in the first language, during foundational years. This poses a dual challenge: to understand the writing process and to develop gather ability to express oneself through writing, and that too in a second language.
- Assessment of writing in a second language through some standardised

written test or worksheets is likely not to reflect a real picture of children's development and potential for expressing in a second language.

10.3.3 Some Suggestions and Recommendations

As facilitators, what can a teacher do to enable the learners to overcome the challenges faced by them during the process of writing in a second language? Some of the suggestions that a teacher can use to facilitate the process of writing are as follows:

Freedom to choose a topic: Messer has suggested that writing about what one knows best reduces the cognitive load that interferes with L2 writers' ability to express themselves in a non-native language (Carroll et al., 1996). Children writing in a second language have a dual challenge: first, to produce the ideas and then to apply the knowledge about the language learnt to create the composition. So, including them in the choice of topics to write is quite helpful. Personal narratives, as a form of writing, can also be included to facilitate the process of writing.

Feedback on content first: Another important thing is to discuss the write-ups of the children. This would not only facilitate organising their thoughts and structure their written piece better, but it would even help in generating new ideas or gathering thoughts around the chosen topic. Leki (1992) suggests that it makes sense to first of all give feedback on the content. He further adds that teachers can provide help for ESL writers beyond correction of grammar errors by showing them ways to focus on the organisational and logical flow of their papers, and especially the feedback that indicates readers' difficulty through direct statements due to a particular error, is more helpful for beginning writers in L2.

Correction: When children get to the stage of editing, correction of grammatical errors must be done strategically and carefully, as they are just beginning to express themselves in writing. Yet decisions about what and how much to correct for a piece of writing depend upon the level, grade, need, and motivation of an individual. For beginner writers, it is fine to focus initially on only one or two aspects of editing at a time. The teachers must observe closely the kind of errors that a group or an individual is making in their writing repeatedly to offer a mini-lesson kind of corrective approach with them to understand that piece of grammar. Further, while revising, be focused on those skills taught during editing.



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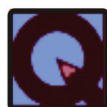


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Flexibility to use Home Language: When a writer cannot produce a word or phrase in a second language, allowing them to use one's own language at that point, to later replace it while editing, is one of the proven strategies. This helps reduce the blocks or hurdles in the writing process arising due to limited exposure and preventing to stop the flow of thoughts. This system recognises that during the composing process, ideas must take priority, and surface details can be manipulated after composing.

Combination of Assessment techniques: A teacher cannot assess every child on the same yardstick or through a set standard criterion. Rather, every child is compared from their own self, i.e., what they were able to do earlier and how much they have progressed now. This kind of assessment is called a Self-Referenced Assessment. For the early years to support and assess the development of the writing process, this form of assessment is most suited. While the Norm-Referenced Assessment or Criterion-Referenced Assessment can be used at the preparatory stage, using rubrics. Apart from this, teacher and peer feedback have a critical role to play along with self-assessment. Since writing is a process, it does not lend itself to a one-time, year-end evaluation. Continuous record keeping of children's work to evaluate progress and to collect evidence of growth for assessment is needed. This can be done using portfolios.



CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 10.1

1. What is the real purpose of writing in primary grades? Choose one option.
 - a) Writing the alphabet in proper curves and strokes
 - b) Writing with correct spellings
 - c) Writing for a real purpose with meaning
 - d) Copying from the board or book accurately
2. What are the challenges of writing in a second language? Choose one option.
 - a) Children have limited exposure, so they may have a need to switch to their home language to express themselves freely and fully
 - b) Children are hesitant to write on their own due to the dual challenge of composing and finding the right syntax, vocabulary, and spelling
 - c) While teachers may be cautious in correcting beginner writers in a second language, they sometimes ask for direct feedback on errors.
 - d) All the above

Answers:

1.c), 2.d)

10.4 PERSPECTIVE ON ASSESSMENT

As discussed earlier, the process of learning to write is a continuous process. In this case, the facilitator faces many challenges like how to assess the children till they completely acquire the skill, how much time does a child take to completely acquire the writing skills, is there any kind of prescribed assessment strategy that should be used during the process of developing the skill, how to differentiate assessment of writing in grades 1 and 2 (Foundational Stage) from those who have advanced in the learning of the skill in the preparatory stage, where they have learnt the alphabet and words, sentences, or paragraphs, and have begun writing fully, though not conventionally like the adults.

We know that each child has their own pace of learning. For the development of writing skills, the same principle applies. If we recall the National Curriculum Framework for Foundational Stage (NCFFS) 2022, it is mentioned that the assessment in early years is primarily to be done by observation of children. This is also a way of informally assessing children and supporting them in their learning. The process of assessment would focus on how they are learning and where they are getting stuck. NCFFS also describes, “The approach to writing should be in the form of expression, not a task. As such, the first step for a child is drawing, then labelling the drawing, which initially may involve invented spellings, which is an important step in meaningful literacy, then realising that one can be more expressive through multiple words (phrases) and finally moving towards complete sentences” (2022, p. 79). It clearly highlights that during the foundational stage, the writing is developmental in nature, and children, before they start writing conventionally, would go through various steps as mentioned. At this stage, how children express themselves through writing more comfortably, like either through scribbling, pictorial representations only, or drawing along with a few words/labels connoting their drawing, a sentence with supporting illustrations, etc., is also an assessment.

As we have also seen in example 1 in the introduction section that children, through keen observation by the teacher, were supported, and she was simultaneously making notes on the assessment of the children individually based on their preferences, difficulties, growth and so on. Hence, when children

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begin to express themselves through a more structured form of writing, it is important to recognise that this writing process is still evolving. For the assessment of such a process, various tools and techniques can be used, which will be discussed in the next section.

10.4.1 Different Tools and Techniques of Assessment

As we have already discussed in previous chapters, different kinds of writing can be done in primary grades, like narrative writing, including stories, poems, dialogues, experiences, information, descriptive writing, reflective writing, personal writing, etc. Now we will discuss how we assess children's writing, which is in different forms and is still developing, using various tools and techniques. We will study this in detail in this section with the help of a few examples. We will also examine how the same activity can be assessed differently using different tools. Through this, we will explore the nature of assessment from the foundational stage to the preparatory stage and how it varies in manner and degree, with some examples from the classrooms.

The purpose of assessment is to support learning, so this should not be taken as an end-of-period exercise. It will be an integral part that may have elements before a lesson, during a lesson and after a lesson, as well as at each stage of the 'writing process'.

Assessment of language may require more than one skill. For instance, in speaking, the listening skill is vital; likewise, for writing, reading is important. Assessment must integrate all four skills of listening, speaking, reading, and writing. Any language assessment should give students an opportunity to demonstrate what they know and can do with the language. Teachers should use a variety of assessment tools and techniques to determine where students are, to set goals for instruction, to monitor students' growth and development, and to give feedback to students so that they can monitor their own development. Assessment is the ongoing process that occurs throughout all stages to gather data about students' understanding, skills, strategies, and attitudes.

10.4.2 Toolkit of Assessment for Learning

As a language teacher of primary classes, it is important for us to know what our resources are, both for teaching the second language effectively to our learners and the means to assess them effectively. Hence, we will learn in this section what our toolkit is for assessment to promote learning in the classroom.



Toolkit for assessment:

- Anecdotal records
- Portfolio
- Rubric
- Checklist
- Rating scale
- Observation and interaction with children

10.4.2.1 Using Anecdotal Record

Let us look at the snapshot of a conversation between two teachers:

Grade II Free-writing in Second Language

Teacher 1: You know my children in grade 3 who are 7–8-year-old also make so many mistakes in spelling. I think their foundation in early grades is not built strongly. They misspell simple words such as ‘like’, sometimes they write ‘lik’ or ‘lick’. What to say about difficult words like ‘nature’ etc. What do you think about it?

Teacher 2: Well, if I see it from other perspective, the understanding of letter-sound relation is still evolving and it is bound to reflect in the learner’s writing. For example, where the child has spelt the word like as ‘lik’, the child is able to identify the primary sounds heard in the word /l/-/I/-/k/, also not able to decipher the sound /e/ in the word ‘like’ because it is silent, For the child who has written the spelling as ‘lick’ I can say, perhaps he/she remembers seeing the word pattern with 4 letters and cannot accurately recall which letter was there with letter with /k/ and so based on the graphic image in mind ended up adding a look alike letter ‘c’ instead ‘e’ with /k/.

In the above conversation, we can observe that children start inventing spellings using their understanding of letter-sound relationships. These are not mistakes; they tell us about how and what the child is understanding about the language learnt and the developmental stage of the child. Any such observations and analysis that give us insight into the developing abilities of the children can be noted down as anecdotal records. These can be included while making a portfolio of an individual child to keep a sample of record of their abilities and selected works in language from different aspects.



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10.4.2.2 Using Portfolio

Arter defines a portfolio as “A portfolio is a purposeful collection of student work that exhibits to the student (and/or others) the student’s efforts, progress, or achievement in (a) given area(s). This collection must include: student participation in selection of portfolio content; the criteria for selection; the criteria for judging merit; and evidence of student self-reflection” (1990, p. 2). Portfolios constitute a collection of samples of student work, assembled for a particular purpose. While the purpose of a portfolio can differ, the content assembled will also differ depending on the purpose and audience. For example, if the students are to be evaluated based on the work in the portfolio, then they would probably choose the final version of what they consider their best work. If the purpose is to show growth over time, then samples of the best work would be included at several points in time. Or, if the portfolio is to be used to track the journey of students over a writing assignment or project, then a complete record of all activities, drafts, revisions, etc., might be kept in that. Here is an example of how Linda Rief wrote a profile of her learner while evaluating her portfolio: “As a writer Nahani knows how to find a topic, how to play with words until they say exactly what she means, how to seek help for revision, how to use a variety of resources, how to ask questions, and how to answer them. She is not afraid to take risks with new genres. She has tried poetry this year ... Nahani has an acute sense of audience” (1990, p. 27).

How does assessment using portfolios fit in with other formal and informal assessments? For example, if any other form of competency testing is used, like a worksheet/exam etc., then what are the ways for assessing portfolios? If we take a portfolio as a judgment indicating the quality of effort or a piece of writing. Can there be some mechanisms for scoring or evaluating these written pieces, or some criteria for making this judgment? These are some of the pertinent questions while dealing with assessment using portfolios.

In attempting to answer some of these questions, it is intended to quote Arthur I. Coasta (1989), “We must constantly remind ourselves that the ultimate purpose of evaluation is to enable students to evaluate themselves” (quid. in Rief, 1990, p. 24). This leads us to the discussion on what the ‘real’ purpose of assessment is and our goal for children while teaching writing. The answer to this is to make them independent in reading, writing, and thinking, i.e., to build readers-writers, thinkers in society who can read and write for authentic purposes in life. The National Education Policy (2020) also emphasises building lifelong skills



of learning rather than just acquiring skills of literacy. Judith Arther (1990) says that including some form of self-evaluation or reflection is an important part of a portfolio. We must begin from this aim in mind and make all our efforts toward supporting instruction in writing or assessment using portfolios towards this end.

There are two more important things related to the portfolio worth discussing here. The first thing is that who is the deciding force regarding the selection of samples to be included in the portfolios? Teachers or district administration? Most educators agree that students should have the primary responsibility for choosing the samples to be included in the portfolio (DeFina, 1992; Tierney, 1992; Krest, 1990; Valencia, 1990). So the children should be given the freedom to choose their samples to be included in their portfolios. In this context, Reif (1996) writes, “When kids are given choices in what they read and what they write, and time to think about what they are doing, their writing and reading get better. When we trust them to set goals and to evaluate their learning in progress, we will begin to realize that they know much more than we allow them to tell us through our set curriculum and standardized test” (p. 29).

Second thing is that our perspective will determine whether we see portfolios as another “add-on” task or as integral and necessary components of instruction. Reif (1996) argues that as teachers lead and instruct students as writers, they must also view and present themselves as learners to them. She says, “My student however aren’t the only ones who keep portfolios. I also keep a portfolio. My reasoning is if I don’t value what I ask my students to do, then they probably won’t value it either” (p. 25).

Portfolio is an excellent way of assessment, as reviewing only the pieces selected by students for their portfolios lowers the number of papers which must be read for evaluation. Also, since each piece selected shows evidence of all steps of the writing process, including revision and editing, this implies that fewer corrections will be necessary at the final stage of assessment.

One of the advantages of a portfolio is the development of a close relationship between the teacher and student as they discuss selected samples. Another advantage is that it more closely resembles the methods used to teach writing. In fact, portfolio assessment parallels life as well. As students reflect on their writing and share their efforts with others, they realise that most problems have more than one solution. Like adults, they attempt various methods until they find the one which is most satisfactory. In addition, students discover that no

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task is ever really finished. Students are able to return to earlier pieces with a new understanding. They can then apply their newly acquired knowledge to revise once more.

Teachers have a larger role in using portfolio assessment. They are helping children grow by giving feedback for revising their written drafts, helping them set goals and select pieces for selections in their portfolios through constant dialogues, tracking their growth and modelling them through the way. Portfolios give teachers insights into their students' growth, which is not possible through traditional assessment measures.

One more question worth exploring is whether the portfolio will contain "indicators" of other mechanisms and aspects of evaluation or just work samples. Some educators may wish to include such items as results from standardised or teacher-made tests, worksheets, and attitude surveys (Cramer, 1993; DeFina, 1992). The student must compose a reflection piece to add to the portfolio. This piece could be an essay, a response to a questionnaire, or a checklist, depending on the student's ability. This reflection may serve as the rationale for including a single writing sample in the collection or for the portfolio samples in general. It enables the student to explain why particular pieces were chosen and the processes the writer employed in their creation (Cooper & Brown, 1992; Tierney, 1992). This process of questioning and reflection is instructive as well as evaluative (Bagley, 1995).

The following is a sample of a student survey or questionnaire for the Portfolio Assessment by Bagley (1995):

In a nutshell, this is how we can make portfolio assessment possible in our classes:

STUDENT PORTFOLIO RESPONSE

Answer each of the following questions as completely and as honestly as possible.

1. How many of the assigned pieces of writing are included in your portfolio?
2. Did you include a table of contents and organize your portfolio accordingly?
3. List the different types of writing which are included in your portfolio.



4. Did you select an example of each of the required pieces of writing for your portfolio?
5. Does each required selection have a selection slip?
6. With which of the required selections are you most satisfied? Why?
7. With which of the required selections are you least satisfied? Why?
8. Give an example of one way in which you have improved as a writer during this year.
9. What grade do you think you deserve on your portfolio? Why? (applicable, if graded)

Table 10.1: Making Portfolio Assessment A Success

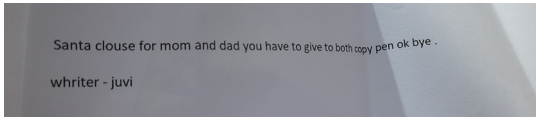
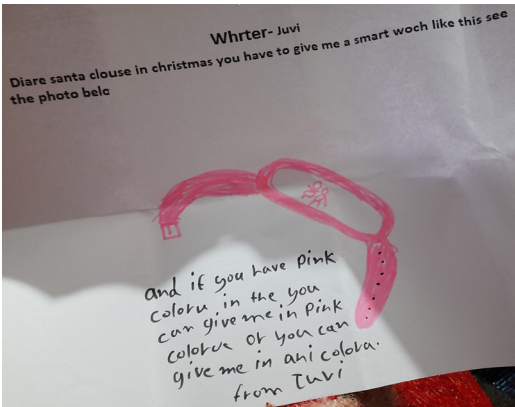
Do's	Don'ts
✓ Students must be immersed in reading, writing, listening, speaking. ✓ They must be given choices about what they are doing. ✓ Indulge in ample writing drafts and reading activities weekly for students to choose from a good quantity of work. ✓ Giving students some reflective questions for evaluating their journey, process, and pieces of work against their own set goals.	- Asking children to produce writing in a hurry, as a timed activity. - Judging their writing or getting to correct their work intensely. - Evaluating and marking students work at the end of a term/period, as this is to jeopardise giving them real choice of selecting their best pieces. - Keeping working samples inaccessible, like in locked almirahs. (It is important to store them in open areas such as in an empty filing cabinet, cardboard boxes, hanging from strings across the back wall etc.)



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10.4.2.3 Using Rubrics

Language, including writing, is best learned and assessed in context. Real-life tasks, meaningful communication, and connecting writing to experiences are crucial. Hence, the rubric can also reflect these aspects that we are aiming to develop. Let us look at an example where we have asked a grade 5 child to write a few sentences on a topic. Then we will examine how we can also assess a piece of writing where there is an expression of the child involved using a rubric.

Writing Task A	Writing Task B
Child 1 writes the following sentences: 1. Cow is our mother. 2. Cow has four legs. 3. Cow eats green grass. 4. Cow gives milk. 5. Cow dung is used to make 'dung cakes'.	Child 1 in an ICT class writes a letter to Santa 
Child 2 writes the following sentences: 1. Cow is our mother. 2. Cow has four legs. 3. We have many cows in the house. 4. The milk of cow brings us money. 5. Jeetu's cow has a calf.	Child 2 in the ICT class has also written a letter to Santa and illustrated and added text by hand to elaborate on it 



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Table 10.2: Sample rubric to assess the written expression of children

PARAMETERS	APPROACHING MEETING EXPECTATION	MEETING EXPECTATION	MOVES BEYOND MEETING EXPECTATION
1. Can use proper punctuation, capitalisation and correct spellings in sentences	1.1 Those who use at least one of these parameters in their sentences	1.2 Those who use both parameters in most of the time in their sentences	1.3 Those who use both these parameters in all the time in their sentences
2. Can organise the ideas well and coherently	2.1 Those who write keeping some focus on the main idea about the topic	2.2 Those who write keeping the focus around the main idea of the topic	2.3 Those who write keeping the focused on main idea along with some added details
3. Can use one's own voice in writing	3.1 Those who write some elements from their observation/ thought on the given topic	3.2 Those who write using elements based on their observation/ thoughts on the given topic	3.3 Those who write some new elements in their writing using their personal experiences/ ideas

The above rubrics have criteria for assessing each level of work prepared by the learner. Looking at these writing samples, we can say that both Child 1 and Child 2 are good writers exhibiting an advanced stage in writing when it comes to the criteria about the mechanics of writing, i.e., grammatical aspects and organisation of ideas in Task A. However, we can still differentiate between the two children based on the last parameter, 'use of voice', in both tasks. It is a very important aspect to assess in a writing piece that is meaningful or has self-expression from the child involved. Child 2's name can be written in 3.2, as the child has written a personal experience about having a cow at home in Task A. Child 2's name in Task B can come in 2.3 and 3.3, as the child is able to use voice in the piece of his/her writing using one's thoughts, ideas and one's choice even when we can see it has a lot of invented spellings and hence can be marked in 1.1. This is still an advanced stage in writing, as the child has

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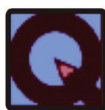
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gathered the real meaning of writing, i.e., writing for communicating ideas/ thoughts. Mechanics will also come with more exposure and feedback. We can also see that ‘Grammar’ is also an inbuilt parameter of assessment in the rubric. Grammar can also be assessed in the context of a written piece, not in isolation. Also, from one writing sample, we can assess many aspects related to writing for a child.

If we are using children’s portfolios for assessment of writing, then there can be some criteria developed for that as well. Possible criteria for making a rubric for portfolio assessment are given below:

- evaluated on a range of content;
- depth of revision;
- students’ willingness to take a risk.



CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 10.2

1. What is not an effective form of assessment while supporting children to be writers?
 - a) Using a rubric for assessing a poem composed by children.
 - b) Giving worksheet to children and allocating marks for every question.
 - c) Making a note in diary after presentation on poster making about each group’s performance on the task with the specific names of children.
 - d) Using a rating scale after completion of worksheet given in the class to grade 5.
2. What objectives or purposes cannot be achieved by doing assessment during the teaching learning?
 - a) To assess students’ understanding and progress
 - b) To discover the needs, interests, and previous experiences of students
 - c) To identify successes or difficulties and confidence levels
 - d) To assess students’ abilities to verbalise their understanding and insights
3. Which of the following statements is most appropriate for the kind of assessment being discussed in this chapter in the context of grammar?
 - a) The grammar cannot be overlooked in any single piece of writing; all corrections must be marked and pointed out each time

- b) The grammar exercise and tests must be repeated regularly for them to be rote memorised by the child
- c) The grammar needs to be assessed separately and content separately
- d) The grammar needs to be assessed in the context of writing exercise and can be one of the parts of parameters of assessment

Answer:

1.b), 2.b), 3.d)

10.5.1 Assessment of Language in Other Subjects

Language assessment need not happen only in the language period. It could happen while we are teaching other subjects like Mathematics or Environmental Studies as well. Language is the basis for all learning. Including pieces of writing from other subjects will provide us with opportunities for a more comprehensive assessment of language learning.

Using other subject classes as a resource for developing and assessing writing: In classes I and II, EVS is taught mostly through languages and mathematics. EVS is a subject that focuses on skills like observation, comparison, classification, etc. These could very effectively be used as a rich resource to develop and assess writing skills during the foundational stage. In these classes, we can find opportunities to give tasks involving English for assessing EVS-related concepts and issues sometimes. Similarly, in mathematics, little sums and problems or some project work could be posed in simple English, and responses elicited from children in simple English also. Like we can see in the example from the Grade 1 Math NCERT textbook given below.

Look at the picture of colourful flowers and write the number of flowers.

Blue flowers  Orange flowers 

Red flowers  Purple flowers 

A. Name the colour of flowers which are least in number. _____

B. Name the colour of the flowers which are most in number. _____



Fig. 10.1: Joyful Mathematics (NCERT, 2025, p. 121)



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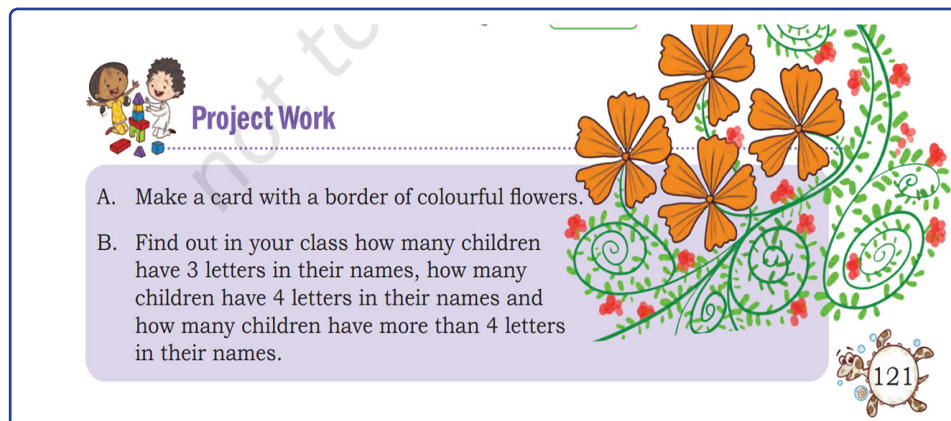


Fig. 10.2: Joyful Mathematics (NCERT, 2025, p. 121)

For the preparatory stage, Linda Rief invited children to include work in other disciplines that they consider their best in their portfolios. She gave examples of the variety of texts/work that came in the class. As a result, Joel had a paper 'The King and his Achievements' which he wrote for social studies, but worked on further in his English class. While Sara and Jenifer included a children's book that they collaboratively prepared for science, based on their field trip for marine biology. Where Jennifer wrote the story, and Sarah, inspired by an artist, is learning about it in her art class, drew illustrations. Through these interdisciplinary works, we would see that children would find the entire school environment a fertile ground for developing writing skills (Rief, 1996).

10.5.2 Attitude and Process of Learning are Equally Important



Fig. 10.3: Different Teaching Approaches
Six Month Certificate Course (Bridge) in Primary Teacher Education



What can you see in the two pictures given above? We need to understand that children from their early grades only form associations about the learning process and about themselves as learners based on the experience of learning they receive in school. In the two examples, children in grade 1 are receiving different instructions that we can compare, and so will be the notions they are likely to develop about themselves as learners and about their understanding of “writing”. While assessing children, we as teachers must be concerned about what associations or meanings the children will make about ‘writing’ whenever a task is given to them. Will they see it as a meaningful process where the writing activity is done to communicate some meaning to someone, or see the writing process as a mechanical exercise where only the formation of letters and knowing correct spelling and grammar structures matter? Apart from skills and ability, attitude towards learning, to be more specific, language learning in this context also needs to be assessed. We need to make that also an integral part of our assessment for language, especially when it concerns the learning of second language. If children have faith in their own abilities and find the learning environment positive and supportive, they will learn better.

The NCFFS 2022 lays special emphasis on the learning environment and positive learning habits. Some of the noteworthy aspects are: Does the child ask questions? Is he/she able to follow arguments and make their own? What does she/he do when confronted with a new type of problem, etc? Assessment is essentially a process of gathering information. In the assessment of learning, if marks alone are used, they do not tell us much about what is being learnt or how. Even the child’s statement ‘I don’t know’ provides us with more valuable information, and we must not mark ‘zero’ for the question. In addition to telling us that the child does not know the answer, it does tell us that the child is confident and comfortable enough to say that she does not know.

10.5.3 Feedback as an Important Technique for Assessment of Writing

As stated by Prof. Krishan Kumar (2018), “Writing is a kind of talk. As we write, we communicate with someone although most often the person we are communicating with is not present in front of us. At the same time it is true that we do a lot of writing simply to preserve something -- a piece of information, an idea, a memory” (p. 33). Written Feedback on a child’s written piece has an inherent role in the assessment process. Giving feedback on children’s written work not only provides a learning opportunity for them but also presents a view of establishing a dialogue or another way of communication with young

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children. In the end of the note preferably write your name to give it a full feeling of a personalised message because the tone has to be welcoming not authoritative.

Finally, it is a personalised message because it cannot be copy pasted in everyone's note as it is. We will have to find what relevant comments we want to give to each child's written work, even though the objective and desired outcome are the same. We must remember that every child is different, so are their needs and pace and hence our feedback must be keeping that in mind for that child.

Last, but not the least, initially this may seem overwhelming and you may not be able to find ideas in mind as to what to write beneath the child's work. But remember writing constructive feedback is a skill like any other skills such as writing itself and gradually with practice we can master it. Moreover, the effects it will have on the overall learning process and the learning environment of the classroom is very far reaching children.

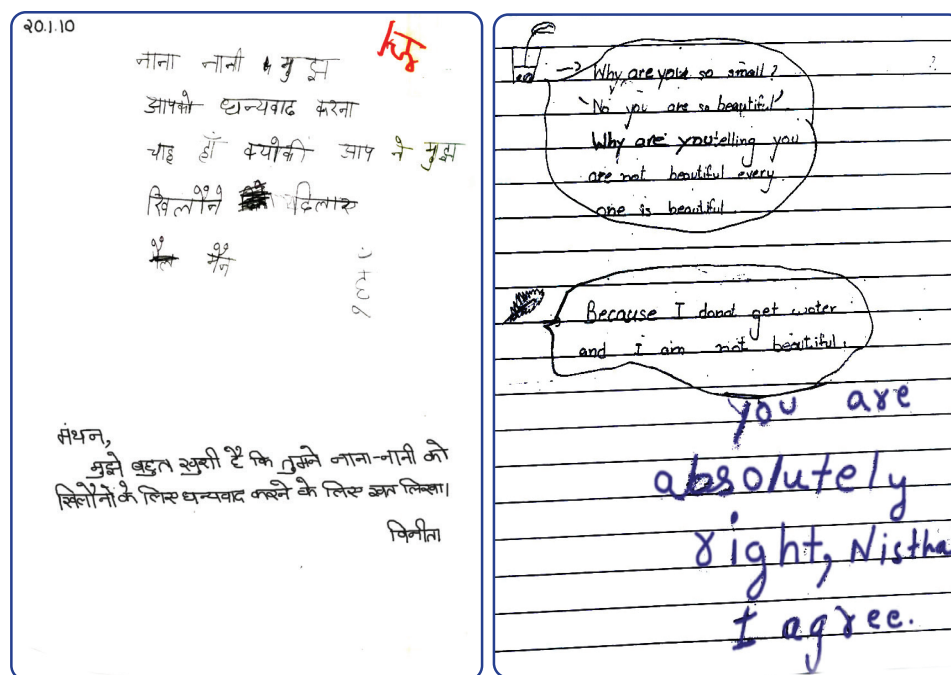


Fig. 10.4: Likhne Ki Shuruaat ek Samvad (NCERT, 2013, p. 37; 49)

For very young children, this adds an additional layer of modelling of the writing process and formal aspects of using a particular language being written by the teacher. Research on second language acquisition and the quality of feedback provided during the process reveals some guiding light to our assessment



process to make it more effective. Semke found via an experimental study that L2 student writers who received content-focused written comments on their journals spent more time writing and became more fluent than those students whose journals received error corrections (Carroll, 1996). This finding is very useful in the context of our discussion, where we are highlighting the importance of written constructive feedback to children's work. Hence, feedback as a means for assessment for learning is a very crucial technique, and we must master this to the best of our ability.

10.5.3.1 How to Provide Written Feedback on the Children's Written Work?

By writing constructive feedback, we are sure to reach the student's heart, along with helping them move in the direction of the desired outcome. If we feel that initially lengthy comments in a second language may be overwhelming to the children, we can start with a simple one-liner text that we strongly want to say to the child about that piece of writing. Some such examples of constructive feedback can be seen in the picture given below:

It is also important to remember that when a child writes a story or a letter, they want to say or express something. The child also wants the teacher to read their thoughts and comment on them. In such a situation, instead of the child's thoughts, if more attention is directed at the spellings and sentence structures, that might make them consider that their thoughts are not valued in the class. Gradually, the originality and lucidity of their thoughts wane, and their creativity is weakened.

Hence, corrections or suggestions for the improvement of children's free expression or creative expression are only to be taken as a gradual process, not to correct everything in every piece of writing. It is an immense act of patience by the teachers, yet they do not losing sight of the assessment of what needs improvement in children's work or our teacher-learning process in our reflective diary or anecdotal record book.

10.5.4 Making Assessment Inclusive Process

Our classrooms are very diverse in every sense. Children come from various linguistic, socio-cultural, religious, ethnic, and regional backgrounds. Despite these, we also find diversity in the children's learning needs, levels, and styles. We know that children can also have some special learning needs, and early

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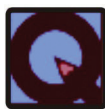


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identification of that is very important for providing additional support in the form of some extra resources or some slight modification and accommodation in our way of teaching for an inclusive class experience. Even in cases where remediation by an intervention by the special educator is needed, we know an early screening and identification is the key. Hence, we must keep the varied views of our learners in mind while assessing as well. The following parameters can be kept in mind for this:

- **Handwriting as an Indicator:** It is important to study handwriting as an indicator of Dyslexia. This suggests that handwriting is considered not just as a skill but also as a potential assessment tool for identifying learning difficulties. This implies that observation and analysis of a child's handwriting can be part of assessing their overall writing development and identifying potential issues that need support.
- **Emphasis on Variety in Teaching Techniques:** Advocating for the use of various techniques for teaching writing implies that assessment should also be varied. If teaching methods need to be diverse to cater to different learners, then assessment should not rely solely on one type of evaluation. This could mean incorporating process-based assessment, where drafts and revisions are considered, not just the final product.
- **Mistakes as Part of Learning:** It is important to note that mistakes by the child are a natural part of the learning process. This suggests an assessment approach that values progress and acknowledges errors as learning opportunities rather than focusing solely on error-free work. It implies a more formative assessment approach where feedback and guidance are prioritised over punitive grading.
- **Balance Between Accuracy and Free Expression:** The important point to consider while assessing the child is whether the focus should be on accuracy or uninhibited expression. It is suggested that the assessment should consider both aspects. While grammatical accuracy and correctness are important, the ability to freely express ideas and thoughts in writing should also be valued and assessed.



CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 10.3

1. 'Balance between accuracy and free expression', what is implied by this? Choose from the options below:



- a) Both are important, while we want to assess accuracy but ability to express freely should also be valued and assessed.
 - b) Accuracy is more important at the early stage as the foundational stage is base of all future learning
 - c) We need to give accuracy and free expression appropriate weightage to strike a balance
 - d) Free expression will make the teaching learning more balanced as children will take more charge of their learning and hence learn accuracy themselves
2. While giving constructive feedback to the child, what is not so important to consider?
- a) Writing in the manner of personalised message using the child's name
 - b) Pointing out to every mistake of spelling or grammar made by the child
 - c) Specifically mentioning what is good or areas of improvement in the child's writing
 - d) Writing our name at the end of the feedback

Answers:

1.a), 2.b)



10.6 LET US SUM UP

- In the initial stages of language learning, particularly in speaking and writing, emphasis should be on free expression. This encourages students to use the language without fear of errors, building confidence and fluency. Assessment might focus on the communication of ideas rather than rigid grammatical accuracy.
- Once students gain confidence and basic fluency, the focus can gradually shift towards accuracy. Correctness in grammar, spelling, and syntax can be assessed more strictly. However, it's crucial not to entirely discourage expression, as it remains a vital part of language use.
- During formative assessments (e.g., drafts, class discussions), the emphasis could be more on expression and feedback given in a supportive, non-critical way. In summative assessments (e.g., final essays, tests), there could be a greater focus on accuracy.

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- Recognising individual students' learning styles and needs is crucial. Some learners might be naturally more inclined towards accuracy and need encouragement to express themselves freely. Others might be more comfortable with expressing themselves but need guidance on improving accuracy. This means that teaching and assessment need to be differentiated, catering to individual needs and learning styles. Allow extra time and provide time to process the experiences and the written expression to include all kinds of learners in the class.



10.7 END EXERCISES

1. What do you understand by the term writing with understanding? Explain with examples.
2. What are the various purposes of assessment, and how can we integrate them with different forms of writing?
3. List out the issues and advantages related to using portfolios in the classroom. Do you feel enthused to introduce portfolio assessments in your classroom? Give reasons in support of your answer.
4. If Class 1 children have just begun writing a few words, they mostly express themselves using drawing. What method of assessment will you use and why?
5. Why do you think giving feedback to children is an important part of assessment?
6. Apart from Skills and Knowledge, which other aspect of learning must also be assessed and how?
7. How can you make the process of the classroom more inclusive? Elaborate using examples from your own classroom.
8. What is the way of involving children in their own assessment? How can it be done for class 1? Or how can it be done for class 5? Choose the answer for one of the two grades and illustrate using examples.

10.8 REFERENCES

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